

5 — How the Words Should Sound

(Plain-English version of `docs/11-content-strategy.md`. Read that file for the full detail.)

The words matter as much as the design. Please write real words on your screens — not “lorem ipsum”. Here is the style to follow.

The voice

Imagine a **slightly older friend who loves God** — the 22-year-old church worker every teen looks up to. Warm, real, and encouraging. Never preachy, never babyish, never corporate.

Five things to remember:

- 1. **Warm, not over-the-top.** “Good to see you, Tolu” — not “OMG WELCOME BACK BESTIE!!!”
- 2. **Faith-filled, not preachy.** Invite; never lecture or scold.
- 3. **Clear, not clever.** Plain, everyday words. Being understood beats being witty.
- 4. **Honest, not hype.** No fake urgency. If a reading is 40 minutes, say 40 minutes.
- 5. **Young, not childish.** Respect teens. No baby-talk, and no forced slang.

Match the tone to the moment

Moment	Sounds like
Daily greeting	“Tuesday, July 7 — let’s spend a few minutes with God.”
Streak milestone	“30 days of showing up. God sees it. 🌱”
Streak reminder	“Keep your streak alive. Today’s devotional is still waiting.”
Missed a day	“New day, fresh start. Yesterday doesn’t disqualify you.”
Error	“That didn’t go through — it’s on our side. Try again?”

The more serious the moment (payment, safety), the plainer the words and the fewer the decorations.

Writing rules for buttons and labels

- **Sentence case** everywhere, even buttons: "Start journey", not "Start Journey".
- **Buttons are actions:** "Register", "Read now", "Save". Not "OK" or "Submit".
- **Talk to the person:** "You're registered" — not "Registration has been completed".
- One idea per sentence. Keep messages to 1–2 short sentences. Aim for a 12-year-old reading level, without talking down.
- Numbers as digits: "3 days", not "three days". Money as "¥1,500". Times use WAT.
- **Emoji:** rarely, and only from this set — 🌱 🍀 ❤️ 📖 🏠 ✨. Never in errors, payments, or safety messages. Never more than one per message.
- One "!" at most, and rarely.

Writing errors (always 3 parts)

1. What happened, plainly.
2. Make clear it isn't the teen's fault (in tone).
3. What to do next.

"Your card was declined by the bank" is better than "Payment error". Keep error codes out of the main line.

Writing success messages

Confirm the **result**, not the system:

- "You're going to the December Campout 🎉 Your ticket is in Me → Tickets" — better than "Transaction successful".

Writing encouragement (the signature style)

- Name the **action**, not the person's worth: "You've read 12 chapters this month."
- Point to God, not performance: "God's been meeting you here" — not "You're crushing it, superstar".
- **Never compare** teens to each other. "More than other teens" is banned.

Notifications (the hardest words to get right)

Keep them under 80 characters, valuable, encouraging, never guilt-tripping. The daily reminders sound like this:

- Morning: "Good morning! Today's devotional and memory verse are ready."
- Afternoon: "Have you had a chance to spend time in God's Word today?"
- Evening: "Keep your streak alive. Today's devotional is still waiting."
- Last one: "There's still time to continue today's journey."

Banned: "You're falling behind!", "Don't lose your streak!", "Where were you today?", or anything made to sting. A good reminder makes a teen feel *invited*. A bad one makes them feel *guilty*.

Christian words

- Prefer everyday phrasing in the app: "spending time with God" over "quiet time"; "growing in faith" over big theological words. Save the deeper words for the devotionals, where they can be explained.
- Use RCCG words correctly and consistently (parish, area, zone, province, region).
- Always tag Scripture with its reference and version: "John 3:16, WEB".
- Never use faith as a trick. "God wants you to open the app" is banned, always.

Language

- Version 1 is in English, with a natural Nigerian warmth.
- Build so the words can be translated later (Yoruba, Igbo, Hausa, French are future goals). Leave room for text to grow up to 40% longer in other languages.